

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

HAPPINESS MANTRA

"Seeing the development of Hasudi Ausanpur, other pradhans have been inspired to convert their villages into smart ones"

— JAYENDRA KUMAR, Chief Development Officer, Siddharthnagar

the NITI Aayog's list of 112 most underdeveloped districts in the country in 2018. But the village has fast distanced itself from that disrepute, winning seven national and two state awards in the past few years under the dynamic leadership of its 44-year-old pradhan, Dilip Kumar Tripathi, who has made it his mission to make the village 'smart'.

The entire village, which falls under the Bhanwapur block and has a population of 1,024 and an area of 1,300 hectares, is equipped with wi-fi. The hi-tech panchayat building has a video-conferencing facility. CCTV cameras have been installed at 23 places besides public address systems at the same number of places. The streets are illuminated with 90 LED lamps powered by 45 solar panels. There are underground drains and the walls of the buildings adjacent to the roads have been painted with educative messages. An RO water plant provides pure drinking water to the villagers. In honour of the women, the outer walls of the houses have been painted pink, declaring it a Pink Village. There is a system of door-to-door garbage collection besides an agricultural machinery bank. To tackle the problem of air pollution caused by brick kilns in the village, an outdoor mass-level air purifier has been installed that can purify 9 lakh cubic metres of air per day. All initiatives have been funded from the Panchayat Nidhi.

The Upper Primary School is the only such institution with state-of-the-art facilities in all of UP. All classrooms are air-conditioned. The digital lab is wi-fi-enabled and teachers have biometric attendance. Devendra Pandey, Siddharthnagar's Basic Education Officer, says, "Now, students from remote government schools have a strong desire to become scientists instead of doctors, engineers and officers."

The idea of the space lab germinated in September 2019 when Tripathi, a postgraduate in Ancient History, was watching Hindi film *Mission Mangal* in a Lucknow theatre with his family. Later, he approached Vyomika Space Pvt. Ltd, which was working in the field of space education in North India in association with ISRO. CEO Govind Yadav recalls, "Our team was surprised to discover the awareness about space among the students of a government school in a backward district." The lab was launched on November 14 (Children's Day), 2022.

Two halls and a big verandah of the school have been converted into the lab. Headmaster Manoj Kumar Varun says, "Scale models (1:20) of all the satellites launched by ISRO since 1980 and those that will be launched till 2030 are on display here. These include models of rockets and launchers such as the Polar Satellite Launch Vehicle (PSLV), the Geostationary Satellite Launch Vehicle (GSLV), GSLV MK-III, Gaganyaan, RLV-TD." Light to heavy drones are also on display and students are being trained to fly them. Teacher Ram Kripal Paswan explains, "Students are also learning how drones can be used in agricultural work like spraying fertilisers and monitoring fields. After they turn 18, they can make a career in drone technology with a drone pilot licence from the Centre. This will help stop the migration from villages to cities."

The space lab also has two telescopes of 60 mm and 130 mm besides 12 different models of remote-operated aircraft. Children can fly them from a distance of 2 km. Aided by a 3D printer, they are also being trained to design and print models of aircraft and other spacecraft. It's the only school in UP that has been selected for the ISRO campus tour.

These and other distinctions have made Hasudi Ausanpur a centre of attraction. So much so that IAS probationers and researchers now drop in to study its success. ■